of the villa. The Tsar was then conducted, past the Duke's four giraffes, to the summer parlour which had been specially decorated in the style of a medieval pavilion. During the levee, the Tsar talked mainly to the Duke of Wellington, but also chatted with Lord Melbourne and the Prime Minister, Sir Robert Peel. Count Nesselrode made straight for his former opposite number, Lord Palmerston, who in office had been known for his strong line against Russia, and the two remained locked in conversation for much of the afternoon.[150]

The visit was intended to cement relations between the two great powers, and to avoid the sort of misunderstandings and suspicions which had just caused so much unnecessary bloodshed in Central Asia. As the Tsar told Peel, 'Through our friendly intercourse, I hope to annihilate the prejudices between our countries.'[151] As an exercise in public relations, the Tsar's visit was certainly a great success. London society women were especially charmed by his good looks and perfect manners. 'He is still a great devotee to female beauty,' noted Baron Stockmar, 'and to his old English flames he showed the greatest attention.' Yet unwittingly, for all the good intentions, the conversations at the Chiswick Breakfast sowed instead the seeds for future conflict.

The Tsar, who had little understanding of the influence of Parliament and the opposition parties on government, left England believing that the private conversations he had had with the Queen and her senior ministers, especially Sir Robert Peel and his Foreign Secretary Lord Aberdeen, could be interpreted as expressions of government policy. Specifically he believed that Britain would now join him to partition the Ottoman Empire. But the British saw the conversations merely as a private exchange of ideas and not some sort of binding gentlemen's agreement as the Tsar believed.[152]

Symbolically, the breakfast ended in absurdity and chaos: as some of the guests including the King of Saxony crossed the lake in boats punted by the Duke's watermen for the purpose of inspecting the Devonshire giraffes, the giraffes decided to wade across the water in the opposite direction, before running amok on the lawns of Chiswick House and stampeding the Tsar's party who were waiting on the other bank. The giraffes were eventually led away by the groundsmen in their state liveries, but from this point a long chain of accidents, gaffes and diplomatic misunderstandings would lead inexorably to Russia and Britain going to war against each other in the Crimea nine years later in 1853.